

Anaphora

HHU SoSe 2025 seminar

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1 Course description

"Consider a device designed to read a text in some natural language, interpret it, and store the content in some manner, say, for the purpose of being able to answer questions about it. To accomplish this task, the machine will have to fulfill at least the following basic requirement. It has to be able to build a file that consists of records of all the individuals, that is, events, objects, etc., mentioned in the text and, for each individual, record whatever is said about it. Of course, for the time being at least, it seems that such a text interpreter is not a practical idea, but this should not discourage us from studying in abstract what kind of capabilities the machine would have to possess, provided that our study provides us with some insight into natural language in general." (Karttunen 1976)

The notion of a *discourse referent* emerged from the work of Lauri Karttunen and David Lewis (Karttunen 1976, Lewis 1979), during a time of general optimism concerning connections between linguistic theory and artificial intelligence research. The central idea is that discourse participants introduce and manipulate *variables* corresponding to individuals mentioned over the course of a conversation. This powerful idea subsequently informed dynamic approaches to meaning, which essentially model anaphora as a kind of cross-referencing device (Heim 1982, Groenendijk & Stokhof 1991). Frank Veltman crystalizes the 'slogan' of dynamic approaches to meaning as follows: "You know the meaning of a sentence if you know the change it brings about in the information state of anyone who accepts the news conveyed by it" (Veltman 1996).

Irene Heim's foundational work on *file change semantics* in the 80s led to an explosion of insightful research applying this central idea to an impressive variety of empirical domains. At the same time, dynamic semantics incorporates powerful proprietary mechanisms for manipulating *contexts* in an apparently arbitrary fashion, and even precompiles these mechanisms into the meanings of logical vocabulary such as "or". In this seminar we'll track developments in dynamic approaches to anaphora, starting from classical theories of (singular) pronouns and their indefinite antecedents, and eventually progressing to intricate theories of modality, plurality, and quantification. In parallel, we'll consider what exactly dynamic semantics commits us to, both as a theory of *content*, and as a theory of how semantic composition proceeds. A central goal

will be a re-assessment of Veltman's slogan, in light of recent work that fine-tunes the division of labor between dynamic semantics and pragmatics (Mandelkern 2022, Elliott 2020).

2 Tentative schedule

Seminars take place Tuesdays 16:30-18:00, in 2421.05.61 (Z20).

date	topic
April 8	File Change Semantics
April 15	File Change Semantics ii
April 22	Dynamic Predicate Logic
April 29	Dynamic Predicate Logic ii
May 6	Subsentential dynamics
May 13	Subsentential dynamics ii
May 20	No class
May 27	Anaphora and presupposition
June 3	Anaphora and presupposition ii
June 10	Anaphora and modality
June 17	Dynamic inquisitive semantics
June 24	Plural dynamic semantics
July 1	No class
July 8	Student presentation
July 15	Student presentation

3 Materials

Handouts and readings will be posted in the class rocketchat channel.

4 Prerequisites

- At least one introductory class in compositional semantics, with similar coverage to *Semantics in Generative Grammar* (Heim & Kratzer 1998).
- At least one class covering basic formal methods, i.e., logic (up to first order), and set theory.

5 Contact information

- Instructor: Patrick Elliott (<https://patrickdelliott.com>)
- Email: patrick.d.elliott@gmail.com
- Secretary: Tim Marton: tim.marton@phil.hhu.de
- For any content questions, please use the rocket chat channel.
- Office hours: by appointment.

6 Assessment

6.1 Beteiligungsnachweis

- Send me a short question about the weekly reading via rocketchat, by Monday evening (the day before class).
 - This can be as simple as "what does [this definition] mean?", but please send something.

6.2 Abschlussprüfung

- One class presentation of a research paper.
- A short research note (max 10 pages).

References

- Elliott, Patrick D. 2020. Towards a principled logic of anaphora. lingbuzz/005562. Unpublished manuscript (2020). MIT. <https://ling.auf.net/lingbuzz/005562>. Under revision for Semantics & Pragmatics.
- Groenendijk, Jeroen & Martin Stokhof. 1991. Dynamic predicate logic. *Linguistics and Philosophy* 14(1). 39–100. <http://www.jstor.org/stable/25001418>.
- Heim, Irene. 1982. *The semantics of definite and indefinite noun phrases*. University of Massachusetts - Amherst dissertation.
- Heim, Irene & Angelika Kratzer. 1998. *Semantics in generative grammar* (Blackwell Textbooks in Linguistics 13). Malden, MA: Blackwell. 324 pp.
- Karttunen, Lauri. 1976. Discourse Referents. In *Notes from the Linguistic Underground*, 363–385. Brill. https://doi.org/10.1163/9789004368859_021.
- Lewis, David. 1979. Scorekeeping in a Language Game. *Journal of Philosophical Logic* 8(1). 339–359. <http://www.jstor.org/stable/30227173>.
- Mandelkern, Matthew. 2022. Witnesses. *Linguistics and Philosophy*.

Veltman, Frank. 1996. Defaults in Update Semantics. *Journal of Philosophical Logic* 25(3). 221–261. <http://www.jstor.org/stable/30226572>.